

Road to Battlefield: Central Eurasia's gateway to TechCrunch Startup Battlefield

Historic regional competition launches to showcase Central Eurasia's rising startup ecosystem on Silicon Valley's biggest stage.

For the first time in its history, Central Eurasia will have a direct pathway to TechCrunch Startup Battlefield through the launch of "Road to Battlefield," a groundbreaking regional competition that promises to put the underrepresented region firmly on the global innovation map.

The competition, organized by Silkroad Innovation Hub in partnership with TechCrunch and Freedom Holding, will span nine countries across Central Eurasia: Azerbaijan, Georgia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Mongolia, Tajikistan, Türkiye, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan. National competitions will lead to a regional final where the top three startups will earn spots in TechCrunch Startup Battlefield 2025 in San Francisco.

"We've been exhibiting startups at TechCrunch Disrupt for several years as partners — 14 startups in 2023, 24 startups in 2024 — and we see that they can be competitive," said Asset Abdualiyev, CEO and founder of Silkroad Innovation Hub. "In 2024, we had the largest pavilion at TechCrunch Disrupt. We are happy to take our partnership with TechCrunch Disrupt to the next level by providing direct access to TechCrunch Startup Battlefield 200 to the most promising startups from the Central Eurasian region."

A region ready for recognition

Central Eurasia's startup ecosystem has been quietly building momentum, representing a dynamic tech hub of 100 million people with one of the youngest populations in the world. The region produces approximately 200,000 STEM graduates annually and is home to an estimated 7,000 active startups across key sectors, including AI, fintech, edtech, medtech, and e-commerce.

The numbers tell a compelling story: Venture funding in Central Asia and the South Caucasus has grown 5.5x in recent years, reaching \$110 million in 2023 and \$150 million in the first half of 2024 alone.

Notable successes include AI company Higgsfield, valued at over \$100 million, and Uzum from Uzbekistan, which raised \$114 million in funding, becoming the country's first unicorn with a valuation of \$1.16 billion. Meanwhile, regional offices of global players, such as Telegram and inDrive, have established operations in Kazakhstan.

Techcrunch event

Save \$450 on your TechCrunch All Stage pass

Build smarter. Scale faster. Connect deeper. Join visionaries from Precursor Ventures, NEA, Index Ventures, Underscore VC, and beyond for a day packed with strategies, workshops, and meaningful connections.

Save \$450 on your TechCrunch All Stage pass

Build smarter. Scale faster. Connect deeper. Join visionaries from Precursor Ventures, NEA, Index Ventures, Underscore VC, and beyond for a day packed with strategies, workshops, and meaningful connections.

Boston, MA | July 15

[REGISTER NOW](#)

Despite this growth, the region's potential remains largely untapped by global investors. The Road to Battlefield competition aims to change that narrative by providing unprecedented visibility and access to Silicon Valley's most influential networks.

"Not all investors understand how vast the opportunities are in that region," explained Abdualiyeu. "This competition is about showcasing that Central Eurasia has startups that deserve global recognition."

The initiative has garnered strong support from key regional players. Magzhan Madiyev, CEO of Astana Hub in Kazakhstan, emphasized the importance of this opportunity: "This initiative reflects the next step in our strategic roadmap to position Central Eurasian startups on the global stage. Residents of Astana Hub are already engaging international markets, participating in U.S.-based accelerators such as AlchemistX, Silicon Valley Residency, and Hero Training, and consistently demonstrating scalable growth. Collectively, startups within our ecosystem now generate over \$1.5 billion in annual revenue — a strong indicator of market readiness and ecosystem maturity. Road to Battlefield marks the next phase in this trajectory: a direct pathway to venture capital, global partnerships, and one of the most respected startup platforms worldwide."

Strong regional partnership

The competition benefits from a robust partnership network across the region, supported by leading regional innovation hubs and accelerators:

Astana Hub (Kazakhstan); IT Park Uzbekistan (Uzbekistan); Future Laboratory (Georgia); Sabah Hub and Innovation and Digital Development Agency (IDDA) (Azerbaijan); IT Park Mongolia (Mongolia); Accelerate Prosperity (Kyrgyzstan); IT Park Dushanbe (Tajikistan); and Startup Centrum (Türkiye).

IT Park Uzbekistan, one of the key supporters, sees this as a crucial step in ecosystem development. "Uzbekistan's tech sector is expanding at a steady pace. We're currently the fastest-growing ecosystem in Central Asia and the second globally," said Abdulakhad Kuchkarov, CEO of IT Park Uzbekistan. "More than 10 Uzbek-founded startups are already operating in the U.S., with others preparing to scale. Our ecosystem is now valued at \$1.2 billion — a 1,200-fold increase over the past few years — and venture funding has grown by 230 times. As local founders increasingly look beyond regional markets, programs like TechCrunch Startup Battlefield offer a practical path toward international growth."

The initiative is backed by Freedom Holding as the main partner, demonstrating significant private sector commitment to regional innovation. "Freedom Holding Corp. has been supporting Central Eurasian teams on the global TechCrunch stage for several years now, and this year is no exception," said Marlen Sikhayev, adviser to the president of Freedom Finance Global PLC. "We believe in the potential of regional entrepreneurs and want to give them access to best practices, mentorship, and investments. This initiative not only provides crucial support for startups but also demonstrates that Central Eurasia's technology and innovation sector is keeping pace with global trends and developing as a unified region."

Competition structure and timeline

The competition follows a carefully structured process:

Stage 1: National Competitions (July 21 – August 10). Each country will host online pitch events.

Stage 2: Regional Final (August 15). The top 20 startups will compete in an online regional final to determine the three winners.

Stage 3: Battlefield Preparation (September 1 – October 24). Winners receive intensive preparation through weekly webinars leading up to TechCrunch Disrupt 2025.

Stage 4: TechCrunch Startup Battlefield (October 27 – 29). The three finalists travel to Silicon Valley to compete in the TechCrunch Startup Battlefield 200.

Exclusive benefits for winners

The three winning startups will receive a comprehensive package designed to maximize their Silicon Valley experience:

- **Guaranteed spots** in TechCrunch Startup Battlefield 200.
- **Round-trip flights** to San Francisco for up to two team members.
- **Accommodation** covered for up to 2 weeks.
- **Startup booth** and exhibit space for all three days of TechCrunch Disrupt.
- **Investor and networking access** to top VCs and private industry events.
- **Branding and media exposure** through event materials and coverage opportunities.

Startup criteria

The competition targets early-stage startups that meet specific criteria:

- Must not have exceeded the pre-Series A funding stage.
- Must have a functional MVP.
- Should have limited global media exposure.
- Must be based in one of the nine Central Eurasian countries.

Building on success

TechCrunch Disrupt stands as one of the world's most influential tech conferences, attracting over 165,000 attendees and featuring speakers such as Elon Musk, Serena Williams, and Satya Nadella.

At its core, TechCrunch Startup Battlefield boasts an impressive 15-plus-year track record of launching global tech giants, including Trello, Dropbox, N26, Mint, and Forethought AI. Alumni companies have collectively raised over \$32 billion, with more than 50 unicorns emerging from the program.

Each year, 200 early-stage startups compete for unparalleled exposure to top-tier investors and media, with 20 finalists advancing to compete live for \$100,000 funding and the iconic Disrupt Cup.

A historic moment

The launch of Road to Battlefield represents more than just a competition; it's a historic moment for Central Eurasia's startup ecosystem. By creating a direct pathway to one of the world's most prestigious startup stages, the initiative promises to accelerate the region's integration into the global innovation economy.

As the competition opens for applications, entrepreneurs across Central Eurasia now have an opportunity to showcase their innovations to Silicon Valley's most influential investors and partners.

For a region that has long been underrepresented in global startup competitions, it could be the catalyst that transforms Central Eurasia into a recognized hub of global innovation.

Applications for Road to Battlefield are [now open](#), with a deadline of July 15, 2025.

Topics

[Startups](#), [TC Event Promo](#), [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#)
[View Bio](#)

July 15, 2025
Boston, MA

From seed to Series C and beyond — founders and VCs of all stages are heading to Boston. Be part of the conversation. Save up to \$425 now and tap into powerful takeaways, peer insights, and game-changing connections.

Most Popular

- [Cursor launches a web app to manage AI coding agents](#)
 - [Maxwell Zeff](#)
- [Why AI will eat McKinsey's lunch — but not today](#)
 - [Connie Loizos](#)
- [OpenAI reportedly 'recalibrating' compensation in response to Meta hires](#)
 - [Anthony Ha](#)
- [Meta reportedly hires four more researchers from OpenAI](#)
 - [Anthony Ha](#)
- [Anthropic's Claude AI became a terrible business owner in experiment that got 'weird'](#)
 - [Julie Bort](#)
- [Google launches Doppl, a new app that lets you visualize how an outfit might look on you](#)
 - [Aisha Malik](#)
- [In just 3 months, CoreWeave CEO, once a crypto-mining bro, becomes a deca-billionaire](#)
 - [Julie Bort](#)